Week 32

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 8 · LESSON 4

Challenges

BIG IDEA

The final week wraps up the year: celebrate, take inventory of how far students have come, and prepare them for what is next. Remind them it is God who does the saving, that they will face challenges and failures, and to be faithful to the gifts God has given them.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. This final lesson caps a year preparing students to be entirely confident and to engage their culture with the truth of the gospel.
2. Take time to celebrate; this has been one of the most difficult topics some students have ever dealt with in church.
3. Do an inventory: have students compare their thinking now with lesson 1.1, ask what questions were answered, and ask seniors if they feel ready.
4. Choose a storyteller who can share failures as well as successes, because students will fall flat sometimes and generally learn more from failure.
5. It is not us who does the saving; some water, some plant, but God causes the growth, from excavators to tree shakers.
6. Encourage students to be faithful to their own gifts; they will face unanswered questions and also the thrill of leading someone to Christ.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Look back at your notes from lesson 1.1. How has your thinking changed since the year began?
2. Have the questions you had at the start been answered? What new questions do you have now?
3. Are you an excavator, a tree shaker, or something in between? How has God gifted you for sharing truth?
4. Seniors: do you feel ready for what is next, and what would help you be more ready?

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WEEK 32 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Final week, final lesson

0:05 All right, you did it. This is the final week, the final lesson of this incredible year of studying apologetics and preparing your students to be one step closer to being entirely confident — to walk across the stage of graduation and to engage their culture with the truth of the gospel. I can't express how excited I am to hear the stories of our students and what they've been able to experience, and the stories of students who started off with skepticism and doubt and have been brought along into committed followers of Christ, proclaiming the gospel far beyond the walls of your youth group. So I'm excited, and I hope you're excited too.

0:54 There are just a couple of quick things I want to bring to your attention and talk through as you prepare. First and foremost, I hope you are preparing to celebrate. This has probably been some of the most difficult topics some of your students have ever dealt with in church, and that's awesome — that makes me very, very excited. So take the time to celebrate.

Take an inventory

1:24 The second thing is to take some time to do an inventory. Go back to when you first started talking, and go back to where your students were. Have your students go back to where they were, and invite them to think it through: what was I thinking back then? Have them go back to their notes. What were you thinking in lesson 1.1 versus how you're thinking now, when the concept of apologetics was first introduced? The questions you had way back in the beginning — have those questions been answered now? What further questions do you have? Where do we go from here? How do we continue to move on?

1:57 For your seniors, ask them if they feel like they're ready. And if they're not, maybe ask them what you can do to help them be further ready for the next step — the next step in their lives, whether it be military, whether it be college, whether it be a gap year, whatever it is. What is next for them?

Successes and failures

2:18 The next thing is successes and failures. For your storyteller, you want someone who can tell a great story about sharing the truth. But keep this in mind: you don't necessarily want somebody who successfully shared the gospel every time. Students are going to need to see some examples of falling flat on their face, because they probably are going to, and that's okay. Maybe that's a good thing, because you generally learn a lot more from failure than you do from successes. So have somebody who can express both sides, especially if you can find somebody who failed, learned from that failure, and moved on to some success.

God gives the growth

3:05 Keep in mind, and remind your students time and again, that it's not us who does the saving. It is God's job. I have an analogy I've often given students: they're all going to be in different places, and God is going to have all different kinds of roles for them. Some water, some plant, but it's God who causes the growth. And I often talk about the wide range of jobs, from excavation to tree shaking.

3:34 I have a pastor friend of mine that I call a tree shaker, because he's one of those guys who is just so eloquent and so good at talking about the gospel that I think he can just say "bless you" and people come to faith in Jesus. He's just so good. God has gifted him in amazing ways. So I call him a tree shaker. He walks up to the tree that has been ripened by a bunch of work from a bunch of other people, and he gets up there and shakes that tree, and the fruit just falls.

4:09 That may be the gifting of some of your students, but that's not necessarily the gifting of all of your students. I typically call myself an excavator. I'm the guy who just messes people up and gets the land ready to be planted, who gets them all confused and thinking, and gets people ready to hear truth and understand what truth is. It could be all over the map.

Encourage your students

4:32 So just remember to encourage your students that wherever they are on that spectrum, to be faithful to the gifts and talents God has given them. They are going to face some challenges. They are going to face questions they don't have answers to all the time, and they're going to have to seek those answers out. They are also going to have awesome success, and they're going to get the thrill of leading someone to know Christ.

Tell us your stories

4:56 And remember, we continue to pray for you. We continue to work really hard here back at the home office to provide you with the best possible resources for you to disciple your students. Like I said, we would love to hear your stories. We would love to hear how this study has impacted you and impacted your students. Share them on Facebook, share them on Twitter and Instagram. Give us an email, give us a phone call — whatever it takes, let us know how this study has impacted you and impacted your students in your ministry.